



# GLOSSARY

**Action**

The mechanism of a gun involving the loading and firing of a cartridge and the ejection of the spent cartridge.

**Artillery**

Guns that are too big and heavy to be fired by hand, including cannon, and also smaller weapons, such as swivel guns.

**Assault rifle**

A short-barreled, easily portable rifle capable of selective fire—semiautomatic or automatic fire—and utilizing a high-capacity magazine with medium- and small-caliber cartridges with short cases.

**Automatic**

Describes a firearm that will load and fire continually while the trigger is kept pulled.

**Barrel shroud**

A covering attached to the barrel of a firearm that insulates the user's hands from the hot barrel.

**Battery**

A group of artillery weapons—usually four to eight.

**Bayonet**

A blade designed to fit into, over, under, or around the muzzle end of a firearm, enabling it to be used as a close-combat weapon.

**Blowback**

A type of firearm operation in which the loading cycle is driven by the motion of the spent cartridge case as it is pushed backward by the exploding gases, which are produced by the ignition of the propellant.

**Blunderbuss**

A muzzle-loading firearm with a short barrel and a flared muzzle.

**Bolt**

In bolt-action weapons, the rod-shaped part that closes and seals the breech. It loads and extracts cartridges and carries the firing pin. It is also present in recoil- and gas-operated self-loading weapons.

**Bolt action**

A mechanism for loading a firearm at its breech. In guns featuring this action, the bolt is manually moved using a small handle. The breech opens, and the spent cartridge case is ejected while a fresh round is chambered.

**Bore**

The internal diameter of a gun's barrel.

**Box-lock**

A variant of the flintlock mechanism in which the cock was placed centrally inside the pistol. In later firearms, the term is used to describe a firing mechanism enclosed within a box-shaped housing in the breech.

**Break-open**

An action in which the barrel hinges downward before the trigger guard for loading at the breech of the firearm.

**Breech**

The rear part of the bore of a firearm or artillery piece.

**Breechblock**

An iron or steel component that slides or hinges to expose the breech of a barrel to allow reloading, and against which the cartridge rests while being fired.

**Breech-loader**

A firearm in which the propellant and projectile are loaded at the breech of the barrel.

**Bridle**

A piece of metal projecting from the pan of a flintlock to support the head of the frizzen's pivot screw; also, a bridging piece inside a gunlock to stabilize the inner end of the axle of the tumbler (part of the sear mechanism).

**Bullpup**

A type of rifle configuration in which the firing mechanism is set in the butt, allowing for a normal-length barrel in a relatively short weapon. It also allows the magazine to be housed behind the trigger.

**Butt**

The part of a long gun held to the shoulder or the part of a pistol held in the hand.

**Caliber**

The internal diameter of a weapon's barrel; also used to describe specific cartridge types.

**Carbine**

A short-barreled rifle or musket. Among muzzle-loading firearms, a carbine was often of lighter caliber than a long musket.

**Cartridge**

A wrapping of paper containing a measured charge of gunpowder and a ball or bullet (in muzzle-loading firearms); a tube, usually metallic, containing propellant, primer, and projectile (in breech-loading guns).

**Center-fire**

Describes a self-contained cartridge carrying the chemical primer in the center of its head. It is the most modern form of metallic cartridge.

**Chamber**

The part of a firearm from which the projectile is fired.

**Cleaning rod**

A metal device used to clean residue in the barrel.

**Cock**

The clamp that holds the flint in a flintlock gun; the act of pulling back a hammer, bolt, or cocking handle to ready a gun for firing.

**Cycle**

The series of operations necessary to fire a round and return the gun to its firing position.

**Cyclic rate**

An estimated rate of fire of an automatic weapon.

**Cylinder**

The part of a revolver that holds cartridges in separate chambers usually placed parallel to a central axis.

**Discharger cup**

A cup fixed to the end of a musket or rifle to accept grenades or missiles for firing.

**Dog**

The spring-loaded arm that holds the iron pyrite in a wheel-lock gun.

**Double-action**

An action type, typical of a revolver, in which the hammer can be cocked either automatically by pulling the trigger, or manually.

**Extractor**

The moving part of a firearm that removes spent cartridge cases from the chamber after firing.

**Field gun**

A portable artillery piece that was towed alongside infantry and cavalry on the battlefield. In the 18th and 19th centuries, it fired solid shot, explosive shells, and canister shot (shot made of smaller balls). Modern field guns fire shells.

**Firing pin**

A thin rod that strikes the primer of a center-fire cartridge when the trigger is pulled. It can be moved by an external hammer on the gun or, in firearms with bolts, positioned at the end of the bolt.

**Flash hider**

A device that conceals the flash of burning gases exiting the muzzle on firing a gun.

**Flint**

A piece of stone with a sharp edge that is capable of producing sparks when that edge is struck against hardened steel.

**Flintlock**

A firing mechanism in which a flint strikes a hardened steel surface, creating sparks that ignite the priming powder.

**Forestock**

The part of the stock of a firearm under the barrel and forward of the trigger guard.

**Frizzen**

In the flintlock mechanism, a curved metal plate, formed by the union of the pan cover and striking steel that is usually hinged and struck by a flint.

**Fulminate**

A detonating chemical used as a primer to ignite the main powder charge in the case of percussion locks and all subsequent types of firing mechanism.

**Gas operation**

A type of autoloading action in which the loading cycle is driven by the gases produced by igniting the propellant.

**General-purpose machine-gun (GPMG)**

A multipurpose machine-gun that works either as a light or a medium machine-gun and is mounted on a bipod or tripod.

**Grenade**

A small bomb that can be fired by grenade-launchers and also by some rifles. In the case of rifles, the grenade is mounted on the muzzle and propelled by firing a blank cartridge down the barrel.

**Gunlock**

The firing mechanism on a small arm.

**Gunpowder**

A mixture of saltpetre, charcoal, and sulfur. Until the 1880s, the sole propellant used in small arms and artillery.

**Halberd**

A weapon with a short, wide, axlike blade, a spearpoint, and a back pike for penetrating armor.

**Hammer**

An externally-mounted spring-driven part that is cocked by hand. When released by the trigger, it struck the cap on the nipple of a percussion firearm, or the cartridges of revolvers and earlier kinds of breech-loading sporting guns and rifles.

**Hand-cannon**

A small, crude, cannonlike firearm dating from the early 15th century. It was equipped with a wooden tiller to direct it.

**Harquebus**

A man-portable firearm that evolved from the hand-cannon. It was equipped with a wooden stock to rest it against the user's shoulder, arm, or chest, and was originally fired by a handheld match-cord.

**Heavy machine-gun**

A machine-gun chambered for a round of larger-than-rifle caliber, usually 12.7mm. It was usually fired from a fixed mount.

**Hinged frame**

A pistol in which the barrel can be hinged down to expose the chamber.

**Hold-open device**

A catch that holds back a long gun's bolt if there is no cartridge to be chambered; it also holds the slide of a self-loading pistol back so that the weapon may be dismantled.

**Howitzer**

A high-angle, long-range artillery piece, fitted with a shorter barrel than a field gun, used for destroying fortifications and trench systems. After World War I, howitzers come to include longer-barreled weapons.

**Hydropneumatic recoil**

A type of recuperator mechanism for artillery. Metal tubes below the barrel were partially filled with liquid. As the barrel recoiled on firing, the liquid was forced back in the tubes, compressing the air, which acted as a natural spring to return the barrel to its rest position.

**Iron pyrite**

A natural mineral that was used to produce sparks for igniting the priming powder in the wheel-lock mechanism.

**Lanyard ring**

A ring on the butt of a pistol or revolver by which the user can attach the weapon to his body using a cord or strap.

**Lever action**

A mechanism for loading a gun at its breech. The lever is used to open the breech chamber.

**Light machine-gun (LMG)**

A machine-gun chambered for rifle-caliber ammunition, but not capable of sustained fire.

**Lock plate**

An iron or steel plate around which a gun's lock mechanism is built; the main part of many forms of gunlock.